

COMBAT & DIFFICULTY

Warden's Guide material: running combat and detachments at the table, and calibrating difficulty on the fly.

COMBAT

Combat in Cairn is fast, hectic, and often lethal. In addition, the rules of combat are unique in a few key ways:

- ♦ **Side Initiative:** With the exception of the first round (when PCs must first save DEX to secure their turn), both the PCs and their opponents take turns acting together. The results of a side's individual actions occur simultaneously.
- ♦ **Attacks Automatically Hit:** Combatants typically deal damage to their targets automatically, without rolling to see whether an attack "hits." When multiple attackers target the same foe, only the highest dice result is used in the attack.
- ♦ **Hit Protection and Scars:** Hit Protection acts as a measurement of skill, stamina, resilience, and luck. It also refills automatically when the PC is safe and comfortable. If damage reduces a PC's HP to exactly 0, they receive a *Scar*, which can yield both positive and negative consequences.
- ♦ **Critical Damage:** Damage that reduces a target's HP below zero is subtracted from their STR by the amount of damage remaining. The target must then immediately make a STR save to avoid taking Critical Damage, using their new STR score. On a fail, the target is defeated.

COMBAT EXAMPLE

After days of stepping through endless muck and gloom, the party has finally found the barrow belonging to the Cutlass King, the notorious bandit of a bygone age.

Warden: *"Finally, you reach the point marked on your map, and in the early morning light, the barrow's entrance becomes visible through the thick mist. But as the rolling fog begins to clear, you see a flash of colorful movement near the tomb's entrance."*

Freya: *"Nothing is ever easy, is it? That must be our dear friends from the Ursine Conclave, trying to steal our thunder!"*

Lucius: *"Come now, we don't know that there is an immediate danger. Right?"*

Wolfram: *"It doesn't matter; we must be prepared for whatever comes next. Keep your weapons down, and I'll shout. Perhaps we can avoid bloodshed yet."*

Warden: *"You bark a traditional warning in the direction of the barrow. There is no immediate response, then only a snicker. They appear to be laughing at you! Moments later, three figures step out of the mist and directly into your line of view, each brandishing a weapon. The largest of the three grins as he wields a two-handed war ax, and the other two (a man and woman who are clearly siblings) carry identical swords. Everyone roll a DEX save to see if you can act before they do."*

Wolfram, Lucius, and Freya each save DEX to see whether they can take a turn in the first round. Wolfram and Freya succeed, but Lucius does not.

Lucius: *"Well, shoot. I guess I fumbled my cane sword in all the excitement?"*

Warden: *"Indeed. Alright, Wolfram and Freya, each of you can move and take one action this turn. Assuming they survive, your three opponents will then have a chance to retaliate. Then it will be the PCs' turn to act, including Lucius."*

Wolfram: *"I don't have my crossbow ready, so I'm going to go after the big one with my silver knife. If we can take him down, the others might flee."*

Freya: *"Hey, that was my plan as well! Why don't we both go after him?"*

Wolfram and Freya each make individual attack rolls, but only the highest number counts as damage against the large man [8 HP, 15 STR, 7 DEX, 9 WIL, battleaxe (d10)]. Wolfram rolls a 4, and Freya a 5 and a 1 for each dagger respectively.

Warden: *"You each rush the man with the war ax. He easily sidesteps Wolfram's initial jab but nearly isn't quick enough for Freya! He is nearly eviscerated as her twin daggers slice the air where he stood only a millisecond before. That was a close one!"*

Freya: *"Thanks. That isn't much comfort though."*

It is now the opponents' turn to attack or take an action. Although the description of these events is delivered consecutively, the results happen roughly at the same time. The Warden rolls an attack die for each enemy combatant, targeting each PC only once. The large man rolls a d10 but deals only 3 damage against Freya, while his associates each roll a d6, dealing 1 and a 6 damage against Wolfram and Lucius respectively. As the Warden narrates the results, each player records any lost HP or STR on their character sheet.

Warden: *"Now your opponents will get a crack at it. The large man swings his ax at Freya, but it misses, leaving a wide gap between her and the ax edge. You don't know if you'll be so lucky next time, however. Next, the shorter man stabs at Wolfram, who is the closer of the three. Luckily, the man's blade only glances off his armor. Now on to the man's sister, who nearly takes Lucius's head off with her blade. Somehow the blade doesn't draw blood but instead knocks him back so hard he nearly keels over, and his vision is filled with bright lights and sparkling things."*

Lucius: *"Ouch. I think that takes me to exactly 0 HP. I should check the Scars table, right?"*

Warden: *"Yes, and you'll need to reference how much HP you lost in the attack. Now let's see... You had 6 HP but no armor, and you took 6 damage in the attack. That means you should receive a **Reorienting Head Wound!**"*

Lucius: *"You sound a little too excited about this. OK, it says I need to roll 1d6... I got a 3, which indicates DEX. Now I need to roll 3d6, and if the total is greater than my current Dexterity score, I get to keep it, right? Alright... hey, a 14! That's slightly higher than what I have already! Maybe getting knocked in the head isn't all that bad?"*

Warden: *"Perhaps. One point fewer and you'd have been diseased, and one point greater and you'd lose your hearing for a while. Write down your new DEX score. You really are lucky, you know that? Anyway, it's now time for the PCs to act again."*

Wolfram: *"I shall riposte against the shorter man!"*

Freya: *"I'm going to take another swing at the big fella."*

Lucius: *"I am going to try and stab that woman with my cane sword."*

Wolfram rolls a d6, dealing 2 damage to the shorter man, who has enough HP to absorb the attack. Freya rolls a d6 for each of her daggers, dealing a 1 and a 3. She keeps only the higher die, and the large man is able to absorb the damage, taking his HP down to 0 (but only PCs gain Scars). Lucius rolls a 6 against the woman [5 HP, 11 STR, 8 DEX, 14 WIL]. She loses 1 point of STR in the attack and so must then roll a Critical Damage save using her new STR score.

Warden: *"Wolfram, you stab at the shorter man, but he deftly avoids your attack! Freya, your daggers slice at the large man with impressive speed and intensity, and it's clear that you've put him on the defensive, as you can see the sweat begin pouring down the sides of his head. He is running out of steam! Lucius, your cane sword pierces the woman in the stomach! She makes a STR save to see if she can stay in the fight. She rolls a 13, a fail! She goes down!"*

This is the first casualty of the fight, so the woman's allies must make a WIL save to continue or flee. The Warden rolls using the leader's WIL, and he fails!

Warden: *"The short man sees his sister fall and screams a cry of anguish. He drops his sword and commands the larger man to drop his ax. 'Please,' he begs. 'I don't care about whatever is in that barrow. I beg of you: have mercy. Save my sister, if you have the means.'"*

Wolfram: *"My order takes mercy on all folk willing to forge a new path. If we save your sister with our skills and resources, will you vow to pledge yourself to a life of piety, poverty, and kindness?"*

Warden: *"The shorter man nods, then rushes to his sister. The larger man only smiles, then says, 'I ain't swearin' nothin'. But I do what he says, so long as he pays. Just let me keep my ax.'"*

The party bandage up the woman, stabilizing her. Had they not, she would have bled out within the hour. Now out of danger, the PCs take a quick swig of water and regain their lost HP. Lucius tries to impress Freya by showing off the new battle scar on his eyebrow, but it doesn't work.

Wolfram: *"Alright, that's all sorted then. You lot make your way back to town, and we'll convene later. For now, we've got business with this Cutlass King I've read so much about."*

DETACHMENTS

Detachments are large groups of enemies treated as a single entity. They are more difficult to hit and deal damage to multiple opponents at the same time. Crucially, they remain a single unit until they take critical damage, after which they are broken up or defeated entirely. Occasionally, a large creature (such as a dragon or giant) will be treated as a detachment as well.

DETACHMENT EXAMPLE

The party is setting up camp deep in the forest, adjacent to a modest waterfall. It is nearly nightfall, and everyone is on high alert. Unbeknownst to the party, a colony of Traitor-Rats [3 HP, 5 STR, 15 DEX, 4 WIL, bite (d6), *detachment*] makes its home here.

Warden: *"Just as the sun finally dips behind the trees, you each hear an unusual noise, not unlike the tsk-tsk-tsk of an overbearing uncle. As you listen, it begins to grow both in volume and tempo, then quickly becomes somewhat uncomfortable to listen to. As you survey the perimeter of the campsite, you see dozens of small, rat-like creatures with enormous eyes watching your party. They appear to be the source of the strange sound, and they are moving closer! By the way, we're going to treat these creatures as a detachment until further notice."*

Freya: *"Will we need to make DEX saves in order to attack before these things? Assuming they intend to do us harm, that is."*

Warden: *"No, you have enough time to make the first move."*

Freya: *"OK. I'm going to see how many of these things I can take out at once."*

Wolfram: *"I'm going to find their queen and shoot her. Assuming there even is a queen!"*

Lucius: *"I hate to do this, but I am going to sacrifice 1 use of my bandages to use as stuffing for my ears. Just in case."*

Warden: *"Let's start with Lucius, who sacrifices 1 use of bandages and stuffs them in his ears. The sound all but disappears. That ends his turn. Freya, go ahead and roll your attack dice."*

Freya rolls two d4 dice, resulting in a 2 and a 2.

Warden: *"Freya, you run into the mess of creatures, stabbing two of them with the Twins. They perish easily, but two more quickly fill their place. Even at the edge of the swarm, the sound they make is intense. You start to feel confused."*

Warden: *"Wolfram, you move into the colony, passing through the swarm as you search for any sign of a queen. You spend your entire turn searching and are unable to take another action. However, in the fading light, you see a taller creature in the distance, a white stripe on its stomach."*

Wolfram: *"Bingo. That's the one. A careful shot, that's all I need."*

Warden: *"Standing amongst all the creatures, the sound becomes unbearable for both Freya and Wolfram. Please make a WIL save, each of you."*

Freya: *"Uh oh. I rolled a 15, a fail."*

Wolfram: *"I roll an 11, a success!"*

Warden: *"Freya collapses on the ground, the noise in her ears has grown so loud it has become an explosion of agony. Wolfram, you grit your teeth and carry on. Lucius is unaffected."*

Freya: *"Eek. Do I lose my next turn?"*

Warden: *"That's right, but you can try to succeed at a WIL save to snap out of it. A few of the creatures nearby begin to nibble at your clothes as you writhe around. Finally, they attack both you and Wolfram!"*

As a detachment, the Traitor-Rats have both the *blast* property and deal *enhanced* damage. The Warden rolls a d12 twice, dealing 1 damage to Freya and 6 to Wolfram.

Warden: *"Freya, you do not have HP as you are prone. However, your leather armor has protected you from taking any damage from the rats nipping at your back. Wolfram, you take 6 damage, but your HP and armor absorb the bulk of it. Next time you might not be so lucky."*

Wolfram: *"That's OK, because there won't be a next time! I take aim at the taller creature and fire. I realize I have to roll a d4, but that's the best we've got!"*

Freya: *"All I can do is make a WIL save... and it's a success! Phew."*

Lucius: *"I rush towards Freya and try to drag her out of that mess."*

Wolfram rolls a 2, which is enough to deal damage to STR. The detachment must now make a Critical Damage save using its STR Attribute. The Warden rolls a 7, a fail.

Warden: *"The crossbow bolt zings through the air, striking the white-furred creature in the heart. It screeches and keels over, and immediately the terrible noise stops, as the creatures begin to run off! Lucius, you pull Freya out of the danger zone just as she is coming around."*

Wolfram: *"Thank goodness that's done with. I'm going to go grab whatever I just shot, though. Might make for a good dinner."*

The party rests for the night, and dines well.

VARIABLE DIFFICULTY

In Cairn, players are encouraged to overcome problems by asking questions, thinking critically, and working within the fiction of the game world to curry advantage. The following principles and examples should help Wardens create consistent and fair rulings that both challenge and reward players for their effort.

PRINCIPLES FOR VARIABLE DIFFICULTY

- ♦ Reward thinking outside the box. This may be a simple mitigation of risk, a new piece of knowledge, character growth, and more.
- ♦ Modify outcomes according to the effort that went into them. If the PCs worked really hard to make something succeed despite the danger involved, enhance the result to match their trouble.
- ♦ Emphasize fictional consequences rather than mechanical buffs. Purely mechanical rewards are usually hollow and lack the potential of in-world benefits.
- ♦ Many dangers can be mitigated or extinguished given time, effort, and skill. If there is no real risk, just skip the roll!
- ♦ Create situations that emphasize non-mechanical solutions. A problem is more interesting when the key to solving it can be understood purely within the fiction.

EVENING THE ODDS

Freya is facing off against a Wood Troll after being separated from the rest of the party. Pinned between the creature and a cave wall, she has no choice but to engage in direct combat. She has already passed her initial DEX save and thus gets to attack before her opponent.

Freya: *"I know I can't beat this guy fair and square, so I'd like to know if there is anything nearby that might even the odds a bit. I grew up on the streets, which means I know how to fight dirty. I'd like to try and blind him without getting clobbered in the process. What are my options?"*

Warden: *"I'll roll a Die of Fate to see how dusty things are around here. A 4! Alright, there is definitely some dust between you and your opponent, but you might need to get close to him in order to scoop some up. You'll need to make a DEX save."*

Freya rolls a 13: a success!

Warden: *"You grab a fistful of dust off the ground in front of you and toss it straight into your opponent's face. He staggers backward and is unable to defend himself as he fights to clear the grit from his eyes!"*

The Wood Troll loses a turn as he tries to remove the dust from his face. He cannot rely on HP in this state; damage will go directly to STR!

Freya: *"I know I should run for it... but I can't help but take advantage of this situation. I'd like to introduce this fellow to the Twins."*

Freya rolls d6+d6 for her daggers (a 3 and a 5), dealing 5 damage directly to the Wood Troll's STR Attribute. The Warden then makes a Critical Damage save for the Troll, rolling a 19: a fail!

Warden: *"You stab him with both blades, green blood gushing from open wounds as the creature roars out in anger. Let's see if it survives the attack! Oooh, it fails its STR save and takes **Critical Damage!** It's down!"*

Freya: *"Alright, I'm taking this as a sign. Time to make my exit!"*

Freya flees the scene (no DEX save required), leaving the Wood Troll to bleed out. If she had known that it can slowly regenerate its health, she might have stayed...

TEAMWORK

Wolfram, Lucius, and Freya are investigating rumors of an invisible creature that has been attacking locals in the Wood. They've tracked the creature to its island den just 40ft from the shoreline of a poison lake. The lake is separated from the surrounding forest by heavy mud flats.

Warden: *"The creature's footprints end at the shore of a roiling lake that bubbles and swirls violently. Knowing the history of the region, you realize that if the lake water doesn't kill you, the toxic fumes coming from its surface definitely will!"*

Wolfram: *"We know that the blasted thing makes its home on that pile of rocks out there. Obviously we can't swim across, but I have an idea about how we might draw it out! Lucius, I'm sorry but of the three of us, you're the most... soft. In other words, the perfect bait! Let's make it seem as if your cart is stuck in the mud. I've had a blanket rolled up in my pack for a while now. Perhaps Freya and I can hide under it, then pounce on the creature at just the right moment?"*

Lucius: *"I knew I shouldn't have sported my fancy hat today! Fine, let's proceed."*

Warden: *"The party executes their plan as described, creating the perfect bait for their unsuspecting quarry. I'm going to roll a Die of Fate to determine whether the creature even takes notice... a 5! Alright, that means that the creature definitely wants to investigate the situation, but there's a wrinkle as well: it's starting to get dark."*

Freya: *"Presumably this means that Wolfram and I are able to spy on the island while we hide, right? And that Lucius is still looking the opposite way, pretending to fuss over a stuck wheel?"*

Warden: *"Correct. Both Wolfram and Freya can still see through the cart slats that something clambered out from beneath the pile of rocks on the island, scattering them as it moves towards the water. You can't actually tell what moved the rocks, though. It really is invisible! As you watch, something slips into the toxic waters, making a quiet splash. And its ripples are heading in your direction!"*

Wolfram: *"Well, I guess this is as good a time as ever to bring out my Voidglass Shard! It lets me see invisible creatures but packs a wallop! I won't be able to see out of one eye for an hour, during which time my fighting skills will be... less effective. Might I be able to get a shot with the crossbow while looking through the glass?"*

Warden: *"You need two hands for the crossbow."*

Freya: *"I can hold the Voidglass Shard up to his eye."*

Warden: *"That will work, but you won't have an action of your own until after the creature has a chance to react."*

Lucius: *"Um, what about me? I won't be able to see the creature at all, let alone defend myself! I'd like to prepare an action for the moment Wolfram gets a shot off. I still have the large sack from our last caper. I wonder if I could leap on the creature when it approaches, trapping it like a giant fish?"*

Warden: *"That works! You each prepare yourselves for what is to come. Freya and Wolfram, you wait in silence as the ripples come ever closer. Finally, they stop! Freya places the Voidglass Shard on Wolfram's eye as he raises his crossbow. Wolfram, you see a slimy, fish-like creature climbing out of the water, yellowed scales crisscrossing its multi-limbed body. There is a brief, breathless pause and then a loud TWANG as he lets loose a crossbow bolt."*

Wolfram rolls a d8, resulting in a 6! As the creature was unaware of its attackers, the damage goes directly to STR. It makes a Critical Damage save, and the result is a 3: a success.

Warden: *"The creature is impaled by the bolt, green fluid spurting out of its body. Where it lands, the surface hisses as if in contact with acid. It turns towards the cart, but before it can react, Lucius throws his large sack over it. The creature thrashes about inside the sack, twisting in every which way."*

The Warden makes a DEX save for the creature to see if it can quickly break free from the sack. Out of water, it has only 8 DEX. It rolls a 12: a fail. Unable to defend itself, the creature is quickly tied up and placed in the cart, along with a jar of the toxic water for the journey. Working together, the party quickly heads back towards town.

CHARACTER HISTORY

The party are escorting an agent of the Alsace faction deep in enemy territory. Their destination is hidden in a small village protected by tall wooden walls. Their job is to sneak their client into the heavily guarded town and then into the ancient vault of Der Thunn. As they approach the village, the sun is just beginning to set, and Lucius has been sent ahead to investigate, posing as a troubadour from the South.

Warden: *"You approach the walled village, following the dirt trail that leads directly to the town's front gate. Two guards stand on either side of the gate, which is closed. The guards are nearly identical save for a weak mustache sported by one."*

Lucius: *"Ho there, fine gentlemen! May one such as myself inquire as to whether entry to your village would be permissible on this fine evening? I've had a long journey but am flush with gold and would love to spread some of my good luck!"*

Warden: *"The men exchange a look. The mustachioed guard replies, 'No entry after dark. That's the rule.'"*

At this point, Lucius is putting on all his charm and is essentially trying to bribe the guards to gain entry. He is also the most at risk in this situation, as the two men are well-equipped to handle a lone traveler and have backup besides. If it were required, Lucius would make the WIL save and not the guards.

Lucius: *"Yes, I understand. But it isn't quite dark yet, is it? The Sun is only just setting. May I please enter? I'd happily start sharing my newfound wealth with you two first, if you catch my drift. Perhaps I could bring you each a well-earned beer? To show my appreciation, of course."*

Warden: *"The two men exchange looks once more, but this time the other man replies, smirking. 'Well... perhaps this once. The Sun hasn't truly set just yet. And we are quite thirsty, after all.'"*

The Warden made a ruling based on what was known about these men: they were simple village guards, they'd been working a long day, and they love beer. Perhaps with another character, this wouldn't have worked, but Lucius is a Mountebank, and his capacity for winning the confidence of his targets has been well established. The guards let him in.

GREATER RISK FOR GREATER REWARD

The party has sent Freya under the cover of darkness to spy on an enemy encampment. Her goal is to ascertain their enemy's total number as well as what sort of dangers might await there.

Warden: *"Halfway to the camp, you see a light flickering along the trail. Someone is coming toward you! What do you do?"*

Freya: *"I slip into the foliage on the side of the trail, keeping as quiet as possible. Does that require a save?"*

Warden: *"No, because you've got enough of a distance from this person and you don't have any light sources lit. You may hide without risk of being found."*

Freya: *"If it seems to me like this person might belong to the same faction as our enemy, I would like to ambush them and steal their clothes. I don't want to raise the alarm, so I will need to be fast and furious."*

Warden: *"OK. They will need to make a DEX save to react in time to fend off your attack, then. It might not go as cleanly as you hope!"*

Freya: *"What if instead I just knock them unconscious by dropping a tree branch on top of them? I have a hand ax in here somewhere."*

Warden: *"That might work. You'll need to sprint back a bit, climb a tree, and then save STR to determine if you can cut the branch down at just the right moment, without notifying your target. If you fail, you will come down with the branch as well, potentially taking damage and putting yourself in a very vulnerable position."*

Freya rushes back down the trail, climbs a tree, and begins hacking at one of the branches with her ax. She rolls a STR save: a 7, a success! She thwacks the branch at just the right moment, and it falls atop the lone traveler below her, knocking them unconscious. Freya steals their clothes and their torch, then sets off down the trail towards the camp.

COMBAT IS WAR

Wolfram, Lucius, and Freya are on the run from a *detachment* of twelve city guards [4 HP, 1 Armor, 11 STR, 14 DEX, 12 WIL, short sword (d6)], and they are taking shelter in a burnt-out old outpost at the edge of a forest, accessible only by a single ladder. The soldiers each carry a short sword and bow, except for their leader, a tall man with a bright blue epaulet on his shoulder. The soldiers know that the party has taken refuge in the outpost, and are talking among themselves at a safe distance away, just North of where the party is hunkering down. The *detachment* will be treated as a single entity until they take Critical Damage.

Warden: *"The outpost is partly shielded by what remains of its walls, and through the slats, you see the soldiers split off: six head towards the Southwest, adjacent to the treeline, while the rest (including the tall man) move Southeast, where the walls are the most damaged. It looks like they are planning some kind of pincer attack. You have less than a minute to act before they reach the open-side of the shield wall! What do you do?"*

Wolfram: *"I was in the military, so I know how this goes. That man with the fancy tassel is their leader. If we take him out, the rest might flee. I'm going to wait until he is as close as possible, then fire my crossbow at him. If that leaves me exposed, then so be it!"*

Lucius: *"You're always so direct, Wolfie! I'm going to pour some of my famous Miracle Oil on the ladder leading up here. That should both prove effective and entertaining!"*

Freya: *"And what exactly will stop them from simply firing into our hiding spot from the giant holes on the South side? At the very best, they'll just wait until we run out of food. I have another idea: I'll poke my head through the trapdoor and toss Smoke Bombs towards each side of the building. That'll give us an advantage for when these other two plans inevitably fail!"*

Lucius: *"Uh, I guess I'll use my oil just after she tosses the Smoke Bombs, then?"*

Warden: *"That should be fine, yes. But be aware that combat officially breaks out as soon as Wolfram stands to fire. And since you're all at the ready, there is no need to make a DEX save: you go first."*

Warden: *"The soldiers continue their trajectory, until finally the leader draws his sword into the air and screams, 'Charge!' And the soldiers rush towards you. Everything happens at once. Wolfram stands and fires his crossbow at the leader. Since the leader is part of a detachment, Wolfram can only roll a d4."*

The result of Wolfram's attack is a 3, and as the leader's helmet absorbs 1 point of damage, he loses only 2 HP.

Warden: *"The arrow whizzes past the leader's shoulder, tearing his brightly-colored shoulder epaulet. He grimaces and rushes forward towards the East side of the building. Freya, at the same time, you pop your head through the trap door and toss Smoke Bombs on the East and West sides of the building - mark off 2 uses please. Lucius, you stand behind her, and the moment she moves away, you pour some Miracle Oil on the stepladder."*

Warden: *"As smoke fills either side of the building, it becomes impossible to tell friend from foe. A few of the men try to climb the ladder but immediately slide off, landing at the bottom in a heap. Your enemies have essentially lost their turn, but the smoke is starting to dissipate. Amidst coughing and shouts, you hear a voice cry, 'Burn it to the ground!'"*

Wolfram: *"Well that bought us some time, at least. Hey, Lucius, how flammable is that oil of yours?"*

Lucius: *"Very. And it seems we may be running out of options."*

Freya: *"Well, it's been fun, but I'd rather die fighting down there than get burned alive up here with you lot! No offense."*

Wolfram: *"None taken. See if you can take out their leader while we try to open up an escape route."*

Wolfram: *"I'm going to cast Disassemble on myself, then scream 'he's going to tear my arms off!' I will then drop down to the ground and start running around in circles. Lucius, when my arms are removed, I want you to pick them up and come after me."*

Lucius: *"OK. I really hope this works... And if not, well at least we'll go down fighting! Or screaming. Probably the latter."*

Warden: *"Freya, who will be your target and what weapon?"*

Freya: *"Their leader, and I'll be using the Twins."*

Warden: *"Alright. Freya leaps down to the smokey earth, making a beeline for the leader. She draws her twin daggers, but as she is still attacking a detachment, she must still roll only a d4 each dagger."*

Freya makes two d4 rolls, a 4 and a 1. She keeps the higher, and the leader's helmet again absorbs 1 point of damage. The remaining 3 damage is enough to trigger a Critical Damage save on the behalf of the detachment. The result is a 15 (a fail), and with the defeat of their leader, the detachment is both broken and routed.

Warden: *"Freya slashes at the leader, but her dagger misses as he takes a lucky step back. He is less fortunate on her second attack, however, as she stabs him in the chest. He slumps over, and those closest to him shout in surprise; some even begin backing away. It is at this moment that you hear a scream, and then see Wolfram leap onto the ground from the outpost and begin running in circles, followed by Lucius, holding both of his friend's arms. The others then pick up their leader and hightail it back to the edge of the hill amid screams of 'Sorcery!' and 'We weren't trained for this!'"*

Wolfram: *"I knew that would work!"*

Freya: *"I'm pretty sure this was all me, but whatever."*

Lucius: *"Who cares? Let's just get out of here while the getting's good."*

Warden: *"You have an opportunity to flee into the nearby Wood, or across the open fields if you think you can run fast enough. What do you do?"*